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Millennial Monsters

Japanese Toys and the Global Imagination

ANNE ALLISON

Foreword by GARY CROSS



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have laid out some of the socioeconomic factors and events that have shaped the national mood in Japan at this moment of the millennial crossover and can be traced not only in the “pathologies” of the era—Aum Shinrikyō, social shut-ins, criminal youth—but also in the trends in producing, accumulating, and bonding with “cute” play commodities that define the subject of this book.

As I have tried to suggest, there is a thin line between the “monstrous” behavior of children who, once “good,” retreat into their rooms or act out in random violence and that of so-called normal kids who fetishistically consume brand-name goods and compulsively play with the fantasy monsters that are so popular in (and whose profits are so important to) the Japanese marketplace today. In the discourse surrounding both phenomena today in Japan, reference is made to the same set of conditions: a pressurized school system (of constant tests and rampant bullying), increasing amount of time spent alone, disconnection from others and the inability of Japanese these days to “communicate,” and the transparency and superficiality of a materialist society. Keeping in mind these issues (and how Japanese play goods are situated contradictorily as both part of, and—imagined, imaginary—antidote to, millennial capitalism), I now move on to the specifics of four waves of made-in-Japan kids’ play that became popular and profitable in the global marketplace in the 1990s. The first of these is the genre of live-action morphin team heroes that, beginning in Japan in 1973, took off as the *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers* on U.S. television screens in 1993.

4 ***Mighty Morphin Power Rangers***

The First Crossover Superheroes

In summer 1997, an episode of the children’s live-action show *Chōriki Sentai Ōrenjā* (*Superpower Team Force King Rangers*), broadcast by Tōei Studios in Tokyo, portrays a hot summer day in downtown Tokyo on which a power outage suddenly halts urban traffic. From commuters stalled on escalators and in subways and street crossings, the camera pans to a huge beast hovering over the city Godzilla-style. Standing on two feet, with a body whose pointy protrusions, we soon learn, are filled with deadly radiation, this monster is named—as written on the bottom of the screen—Mashin-jiyū Barabirudā (Machine Beast Barabirudā). Threatening to cause even more earthly destruction, Machine Beast is taken on by a defender robot that, gigantic as well, looks like a samurai with helmet and pointy shoulder-pads. Called Sentai Robo (Team Force Robot), it marches determinedly forward and makes martial-arts movements with its arms, all driven, we see shortly, by a crew of five humans (the *sentai* Rangers, team force Rangers) seated in the cockpit located in the robot’s head. Fighting hard, Sentai Robo activates a variety of powers. In the end, though, the good robot is trumped by the evil beast and shuts down.

Back at the sentai control room, filled with computers and operated by the “chairman”—a middle-aged man dressed in a military-style uniform who designed the robot—the Rangers are distressed to learn that Sentai Robo will take a long time to repair. Meanwhile, Machine Beast’s threats to Tokyo (and, by implication, the entire world) are mounting, and the Rangers are without a defender robot. Turning to the computer system to see if he can find anything, Red Ranger, the obvious leader of the bunch, discovers the presence of a robot buried in the vicinity. This turns out to be Redo Punchā (Red Puncher), a giant robot built by the chairman two years ago that, due to a malfunction, wound up killing the previous Red Ranger.

Because the glitch has not been fixed, the chairman forbids Red Ranger from operating the robot. But, given that there is no alternative and the security of the world is in danger, Red Ranger says that he "believes" in the chairman's invention, and starts it up anyway.

As his comrades—now trapped by the Machine Beast in his huge palm—look on in anticipation, the robot cranks up and sputters into action. But, starting out strong, Red Puncher soon goes haywire, jolting Red Ranger inside. Plaintively asking the machine, "*Naze, naze?*" (Why, why?), Red Ranger knocks his head against the controls and dies just as the robot conks out as well. In the cockpit, the spirit of the previous Ranger materializes and, taking the hand of his dead comrade, transports him to a point above the earth. From there he shows him a natural panorama (the sea, mountains, a ladybug on a leaf) and says: "This is what we must defend." Back in the cockpit, Red Ranger has been reborn, and saying, "We'll do this together," rekindles the robot. This time it gears up with surety and force and then, to the swell of upbeat music, marches forward and starts attacking Barabirudā. Taken by surprise, Machine Beast is quickly trounced and explodes into pieces. As the Rangers cheer and the chairman smiles in relief, Red Ranger claims victory ("*yatto!*").

In the final scene, everyone has gathered in front of the stacked stones marking the grave of the fallen Ranger. Addressing the younger sister of the latter, Red Ranger tells her it was the spirit of her brother who guided him in his victorious mission. They all then turn to Red Puncher, standing erect in the distance. Paying it their final respects, the group stands solemnly as the camera pans in on Red Puncher, shot against the backdrop of a red setting sun.

Blending Superheroes with Heroic Machines: Japan's Postwar Mythology

The myth of the superhero is as timeless as it is universal. An exceptional being who defies the odds to save the world from danger—it is as if the very frailty and unpredictability of the human condition elicit this fantasy. But as Freud has said about dreams, wish fulfillment also rehearses the boundaries of the familiar world(s) in which we actually live. Superheroes transcend the limits of human normalcy, yet at the same time they work to restore what was once normal (and disturbed by aliens, enemies, natural calamities) at home. The superhero myth, then, is about borders: about extending them in one place only to reassert them somewhere else. And as a fantasy as much about normalcy as about exceptionalism, it is not only mythically universal

but also concretely shaped by the times and places in which it circulates as popular culture. The superhero Tetsuwan Atomu, for example, was very much a product of its times: a *mecha* wonder boy who was model citizen and futuristic robot combined. In this fusion of the real with the imaginary were crystallized not only the hopes and anxieties of the recently defeated Japan but also the norms and policies by which the state intended to reconstruct it (a hardworking citizenry willing to sacrifice to their jobs and welcome technology into their workplace, consumer lifestyle, and subjectivity).

Collapsing fantasy into ideology, this mythic superhero stood for an imaginary Japan/ese that, as Benedict Anderson (1983) has argued about the role played by mass media in producing the nation through an image collectively shared, was a product of the burgeoning mass culture arising through the channels of television, *manga*, and animation in Japan's early postwar years. A sign of the future, *Tetsuwan Atomu* also incorporated something of Japan's preindustrial traditions: an animistic belief system in which the border between human and nonhuman is viewed as far more porous than fixed. A legacy of Japanese folklore—filled with tales of hybrid, morphing, and strange beings (human cranes, warriors born from peach pits, snakes that turn into women)—and Shinto-inspired animism, where everything has a spirit from the air and the wind to rocks, rivers, and humans, the amalgamation of robot and humanness here is a sign of both Japan's future and its past.

In 1973, a new genre of live-action superheroes was inaugurated on Japanese television. Called *Himitsu Sentai Go Renjā* (Secret Team Force of Five Rangers) and broadcast by Tōei Studios, this series followed in the tradition of live-action (*tokusatsu*, or special effects) superheroes popularized by shows like *Urutoraman*. The latter, launched in 1966 with spectacular special effects designed by Tsuburaya Eiji (of *Gojira* fame), popularized the dynamic of a cyborgian superhero, in this case, a human morphed into a giant cybernetically empowered, red-costumed hero, who battles an endless cycle of mechanized beasts. These beasts, generically called *kaijū*, became a fad in boys' action shows that still appear on Japanese television today. The story line is always some version of a battle. The *kaijū*, threatening to destroy the earth and kill off humanity, is opposed by a heroic warrior who ultimately (and always) wins, thereby eliminating the enemy—until a new one reappears for the next show (and battle). And, while the hero is the polar opposite of the *kaijū* in that her or his mission is to save rather than attack humanity/the earth, there is also a resemblance: both are different, in powers and constitution, from "normal" humans. Whether they are cyborgs, androids, robots, or host spirits (fueled by the spirits/powers of animals, for ex-

ample), superheroes are as strange a species as the *kaijū*—mixtures of machinery, electricity, and bestiality. This very strangeness is also of central importance in both the text of the media story lines (on the television program, in comic books or children's magazines) and the children's merchandise that accompanies them (action figures, warrior robots). How precisely the body is composed and what powers are aligned with what physical features is a fascination directed as much to *kaijū* as to heroes, with one crucial difference—only the latter can also pass as human by transforming between one modality (everyday and normal) to another (costumed and empowered).

Go Renjā signaled a major shift in the genre. Instead of a single hero, there was now a team (from three to six members) who fought physically and robotically together as a "team force" of cyberwarriors. Working cooperatively as a unit, they also acquired a collective battle mode of conjoining their high-tech *mecha*: creating a mega-tool out of their separate weapons or fusing their individual flying machines into a giant robot. There were other changes as well. Females were cast as heroes (one out of three, or two out of five, usually), and the overall tone became brighter (*akarui*)—the result, some say, of the addition of women, as well as the colorizing of the show with bubblegum-hued morphing suits (red, pink, yellow, blue, and green). Along with these innovations, the tenor of the battle scenes became more consistently victorious and upbeat. While winning was less assured in the 1950s and 1960s era of fantasy battles—*Gojira* was never definitively killed, for example, and Atomu faced many obstacles in his battles fought for humanity, including his own for acceptance—this "strain of ambiguity" eased with *Go Renjā* (*Kaijū VOW* 1993). Finally, emphasis was placed on teamwork, not surprising given that the heroes now came in teams, and also on cultivating spiritual fortitude that is literally and figuratively transformative.

In the words of an American fan, *Go Renjā* represented a new concept in superheroism organized around two principles: (1) a team force composed of ordinary people whose positive spirit sets them apart, and (2) Rangers who have individual powers but who work together to achieve superheroic goals (Cirronella 1996:10). The concept proved so popular that Tōei's Ranger series has endured for more than a quarter of a century. Still playing today, the show succeeds, in large part, by doing its own form of morphing every season. Each year it reappears with a new team of Rangers (Car Rangers, Turbo Rangers, Dinosaur Rangers, King Rangers) refitted with different powers, costumes, and tools. Moreover, exported to the United States in 1993 and—following the *Gojira*/*Godzilla* route—taken up in that Americanized form

to the rest of the world, the *Power Rangers* (as the U.S. version is called) turned into a wildly popular, and global, "Morphinomenon."

Why such a concept of superheroism would be so popular in the last quarter of the twentieth century has something to do with the times, needless to say. This was an era marked by global capitalism and proliferating technologies that is often described in terms of flexibility, fragmentation, and fluctuation. As noted by Arjun Appadurai (1996), flows (of people, goods, money, ideas, and images) move between geographic and geopolitical borders of various kinds (nations, economies, cultures), making this an age of deterritorialization as much as reterritorialization. Production shifted away from the previous "Fordist" model (Harvey 1990) of a rationalized labor force in which core workers stay in one place and earn enough wages to consume what they produce: the televisions, automobiles, and washing machines that, mass-produced, embed both the desires and the discipline of a modern lifestyle. By the 1970s, production was becoming based more on a post-Fordist model of flexible accumulation, a situation geared to quick turnover and a constantly changing market in which companies downsized their core workers, diversified their holdings and product lines, and relied on subcontractors, peripheral workers, and outsourcing.

Power Rangers, as we will see, is the embodiment of post-Fordism and a postmodern aesthetics in the realm of children's mass culture. Its characters are flexible transformers who move back and forth between a mix of modalities: martial arts, dinosaurs, high-tech machines, and collectivities. Their pastiche of powers similarly marks the jumble of worlds in which events take place: an otherworld of intergalactic beings and the everyday world of "normal" teenagers attending school, hanging out with friends, and troubled by pimples and jealousies. The pace is speedy, characters teleport across multiple borders of time and space, and life is experienced schizophrenically: as disjointed, incoherent, and lacking linear continuity (Jameson 1984). Identities shift, moving among those of normal teenager, costumed superhero, armed warrior, and conjoined "megazord" (one season's version of the Rangers' megamachine). While there is a modernist narrative of good versus evil, the story is postmodernist in lacking any single hero, essence, or transformation that centers the plot.

Cyberheroes and the Ethics of Lean Production

The early 1970s, when *Go Renjā* first hit the screen, were a period of earnest rebuilding in Japan, an effort shored up by the first postwar economic boost in 1968.¹ More than twenty years after it had been vanquished, Japan was

beginning to get back on its feet, remade as a nation devoted to pacifism and material productivity. The optimism reflected in *Go Renjā* is a sign of resurging national confidence, reflected in warriors whose identity as cyber-humans is secure, unlike the robot-boy Tetsuwan Atomu in the 1950s. The story here fits that of the standard superhero myth. According to Richard Reynolds (1994), this myth involves heroes who, living as disguised humans in the "normal" world, transform to superbeings, with special powers and costumes, to fight intruding aliens and save the world from destruction. In the end, the heroes revert to their human form and return to the world they have restored to normalcy. As Reynolds has argued, the superhero myth with its heroic protagonist and evil antagonists is a perfect modernist tale. As such, it has been used to promote national patriotism in various countries, as when the U.S. government sent GIs into World War II (where they fought, among other enemies, the Japanese) laden with *Superman* comics. The story of the wimpish Clark Kent, who transforms into a bold fighting machine to defeat evil foes, replayed a worldview of clearly defined enemies, heroes who begin as normal citizens (coded as white and male), and the urgency of preserving the status quo. Significantly, the original *Superman* story, crafted by Jerry Sieglar and Joe Schuster, was far less upbeat: a darker tale focused more on the threats posed to American society by an evil misanthrope (an anti-Semite reminiscent of Hitler). Once it was picked up by DC Comics in 1938 and began publication as its own comic book, however, *Superman* shifted focus and tone, now centering its attentions on the Herculean hero and his transitions in and out of mainstream society.

Created in the 1970s in a country that was relishing its first successes with reconstruction, *Go Renjā* embedded a somewhat different national(ist) subtext than the heroic loners so popular in American comic books (which, despite the occasional team heroes like X-Men, still thrive in U.S. pop culture, as seen in the recent craze of cinematic remakes of yesteryear's comic-book heroes like the Hulk and Spider-Man). Certainly, the American model of superhero individualist not only was popular in Japan after the war (*Superman* circulated widely there, both in comic-book form and in the live-action television show of the late 1950s) but also influenced the construction of Japanese superheroes (in live-action shows, for example, which were popular in this period of early TV). By the 1970s, however, this was no longer nearly as true, as more and more of the shows broadcast on television, for example, were being produced in Japan, and fashions—both in children's entertainment and in mass/consumer culture generally—were being designed more in accordance with Japanese (versus foreign, i.e., American) styles and tastes. One can see this effect, for example, in the difference paid

to the everyday between the television shows *Superman* and *Go Renjā*. In the latter, the scenes before and after attack are downplayed, as if what constitutes daily normalcy in society is still in the process of getting established. In *Superman*, by contrast, Clark Kent is repeatedly seen at the *Daily Planet* offices interacting with Jimmy Olsen and Lois Lane or returning home to Kansas to visit his mom: a telling sign of a national imaginary sutured to such scenarios of a 1950s America at once stable, secure, and mundane.

The real focus in *Go Renjā* is less on the human incarnation of the Rangers than on the endless processes these ordinary teenagers undergo when transforming into superheroes. Morphing is a far more intricate procedure here than the simple costume change and offstage upgrade performed by Superman (who, after ducking into a phone booth, reemerges caped and charged). Powers in *Go Renjā* are dispersed among a team of heroes and diffused across a span of spirits, weapons, and bodily strengths (figure 12). This spread of traits makes heroism not only more collective and multisited (decentered from the type of the lone hero with a muscular torso embodied by Superman), but also, in some sense, more democratic. Relying on a combination of hard work, team spirit, and good *mecha*, empowerment is a feat open to anyone, including women. The emphasis in this version of the superhero myth dovetails with that of the state: retooling normal citizens into high-performing peace warriors equipped with (intangible) spirits and (tangible) tools. And, just like the recycling that was done of GI ration tins into tin jeeps by Japanese toy makers in the early months following the war, *Go Renjā* appropriated yet remade what had been a popular American myth/show (*Superman*) that played in postwar Japan during the 1960s.

Performance—exerting oneself for the nation—was demanded of citizens in the 1970s as it had been during the war years. But the focus had shifted from conquering others to build a Japanese empire (the Greater East Asia Co-Prosperity Sphere) to fortifying the self to guarantee security and peace at home. The new law of the land was the democratic constitution of 1947, written by the Americans during their occupation. Under its strictures, the emperor was demoted from god to symbol of the state, and citizens went from subjects of the emperor to individuals with equal rights. Under Article 9 of this constitution, Japan was further forbidden from bearing arms for anything other than self-defense. During the occupation, when this constitution was instituted, anything that smacked of militarism or patriotism was initially removed from public life; this included classes in martial arts (karate, *kendō*, *ki-aikidō*) at school and the display of the national flag and singing of the national anthem in public spaces. It is not coinciden-

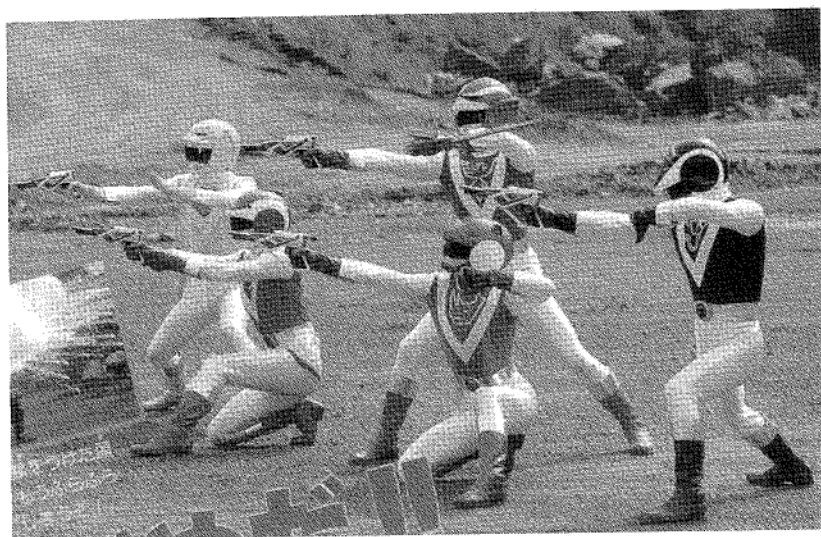


Figure 12. Team warriors: the post-Fordist model of superheroism. (From a *Chōsentai Raibuman* illustrated book for children; courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd.)

tal, of course, that warriorship in the venue of imaginary Rangers is directed against hyperfantastical beasts (*kaijū*) and always in the interests of self-defense. In this guise (a return of the repressed, perhaps), it is also striking that warriorship remained such a persistent and popular motif in this national folklore of a “pacifist” Japan.

Reflected as well in *sentai* mythology is the new industrial model of postwar Japan. Directing its national energies after the war to industrial and consumer production (mainly, manufacturing and service), much of which needed to be rebuilt from scratch, the Japanese government encouraged the development of business along innovative new lines (largely borrowed, at least at first, from the United States). Intended to heighten productivity as well as thwart the union activism that had blossomed after the war, a new model of production emerged that was variously called Toyotism, Sonyism, lean production, and flexible production. Fordism—that is, the standardized, large-scale production ushered in by Henry Ford’s first car plant in Michigan in 1913—spread internationally after 1945, forming mass markets and absorbing the mass of the world’s population (outside the communist world) into the global dynamics of a new kind of capitalism hegemonized by the United States. By the 1960s, however, this hegemony was being chal-

lenged by the recoveries of West Germany and Japan, the saturation of America’s internal market, and the intensification of international competition. According to David Harvey, 1973 marks the watershed year when the political economy of late twentieth-century capitalism was radically transformed from Fordism to post-Fordism, or what he calls “flexible accumulation.” As Harvey (1989) puts it, the rigidity of Fordism made it increasingly less able to sustain the inherent contradictions of capitalism. What was needed instead was a system with greater flexibility to match the uncertainties of the labor market.

Moving away from the Fordist model of mass production, production was now geared to the vagaries of demand (by means of the *kanban*—just in time—system), with workers trained to move between tasks. Thanks to multiple skills and job rotation, employees became increasingly identified more by the company they worked for than by a specific job. Group identity was fostered in other ways as well: all workers at Toyota, Nissan, or other big companies now wore the same uniform and badge no matter what their rank, for example, and separate cafeterias and reserved parking for management were abolished (thereby reducing the gap—so striking in U.S. companies, particularly in salaries—between workers and management). In addition, corporate principles of lifetime employment and all-company unions (in which management and labor work together) became popular, as an ideal if not always a reality, in medium-sized and large companies starting in the 1950s.

As in *Go Renjā*, the stars of the lean production ethos are flexible workers who, though replaceable, are keenly valued for the exceptional service they give to their unit (this is true of the two Red Rangers in the episode that opens this chapter—one Red Ranger is replaced by another, but each has his own identity as well). Team spirit is cultivated, but so is individual initiative (through “quality circles” in the workplace—a concept adopted from the United States), and performance intermixes hard work, spirituality, and high-tech science. Japan’s productivity rose astronomically in the period that also produced *Go Renjā*. In the automobile industry alone, car production increased eighteen times during the second half of the 1960s; by the early 1970s, the output per worker surpassed that in all other industrialized countries (Watanabe 1987). The labor extracted from workers under lean production, it should be noted, is so high that critics call it “management by stress” (Price 1995). Ideologically, however, value is placed on working for something higher than the self that pushes and rewards the superhuman efforts workers put out. In all this, robotic technology both supplements and analogizes human labor. Today the number of industrial robots (350,000) utilized by Japan is the highest in the world (Williams 2003).

Robotic technology, however, is not only physically but also psychically more integral to Japanese industry.

In the long period of Japan's postwar reconstruction, cyborgs have populated the landscape both as laborers in the workplace and as mythic characters of New Age dreams. Their omnipresence in mass culture is striking. Tales of atomic mutants, "ghosts in the shell," reconstructed humans, and cyberwarriors or cops pervade television, anime, manga, and film. And while certainly not all these cyborgs are heroes, the human-machine interface is boldly, often utopically, conceived, unlike what seems the greater tendency in Euro-America, where the *Frankenstein* tradition is still being replayed (with stories of rebuilt humans who turn on their creators or become otherwise monstrous, as in the popular movies *RoboCop* and *Terminator*). Indeed, even in the more recent cyberhit *The Matrix* (and its two sequels), there is a clear dichotomy—and antipathy—between humans and machines, in which the only hope for humanity comes from religiously encoded heroes (Trinity and "the chosen one," Neo) who are trying to break out of the virtual world (the Matrix) that, imprisoning and literally killing them, has been implanted in their heads by machines.

How different is the vision of the cyberborder in the Japanese postwar imaginary as fashioned in children's entertainment like the Rangers? The episode from the 1995–96 season of *Chōriki Sentai Ōrenjā* is illustrative. The symbolism of the story seems blatantly obvious. In this tale of overcoming adversity, all points along the way are hyperbolically overplayed: the earth is threatened by total destruction, the would-be rescuer dies in a replay of heroic self-sacrifice, and humanity is saved in the end by the hero's return from death to rekindle and merge with a master machine. The melodramatic story line is propelled by impotencies (power outage in Tokyo, broken-down robots, dead and endangered Rangers) that are overturned by a megaperformance (the joining together of mechanical, spiritual, and collective resources). Each element operates both metaphorically (machines stand for humans, human-machines stand for the nation) and metonymically (each robot and Ranger is a part of the cyberwhole). And in both these ways, the interdependence and interchangeability of machine and human are repeatedly expressed. Red Ranger/Red Puncher analogize each other: the man defies mortality as a machine would, and the machine is rekindled by human spirituality and determination. They also merge: physically the two look alike (both are red—the Ranger from a red uniform, and the robot from his red metallic overlay), move as a unit (Red Ranger, seated inside the robot and operating it, is literally a part of Red Puncher), and undergo death

and rebirth together (ratcheting the symbolism up even further). In the end, the message is clear: humans are deficient on their own, machines need humanity to be good (unlike the enemy robot) as well as functional (like Red Puncher), and only when they work as coordinated teams—humans and machines, cyborg as tool and myth—is the viability of the world assured.

Transformation and the Aesthetics/Marketing of Detail

Ōrenjā wa hitorizutsu betsubetsu no buki o motte irunda. Gonin no buki o gattaisaseru to sūpā hisatsubuki ni mo narundayo. Muteki no senshi da Ōrenjā!

[Each O-Ranger has her/his own weapon. And, when the tools of these five people are joined together, one superweapon emerges. The O-Rangers are matchless warriors!]

From a children's picture book of O-Rangers published
by Kōdansha: *Chōriki Sentai Ōrenjā* 1995:3

The center of attention in *Go Renjā* as well as *sentai* and cognate genres involving the interface between machine and hero is the body and how it performs armed with powers, machinery, and collective consciousness. As Linda Williams has written about the "frenzy of the visible" in Western pornography (1989:56), the bodily zones most spectacularized (as in made into a spectacle) are those audiences most likely associate with holding secrets. To "see," then, is to "know": a desire both heightened and organized by technologies of visibility—the camera, cinema, video machines, television, virtual reality. In pornography these sites/sights are staged by sexuality: filming bodies in such a way as to make graphically visible what is usually hidden and private—certain flesh zones and interbodily acts that viewers find arousing. Arousal is what sells in this marketplace, and those scenes/sites that are most popular with consumers are called the "money shot." Showing the man's orgasm as it is visibly sprayed on some part of the woman's body (preferably her face) has been the standard, at least in straight porn, since the 1960s in the United States. Using both the Marxian and Freudian definitions of fetish, Williams argues that this "money shot" fetishizes what is valued—and what substitutes or compensates for its lack—both in the political and (heteronormative) sexual economies of American capitalism. Namely, this is performance: a yield in the way of productivity, phallicism, and wealth. Collapsed in this sign of a man's ejaculate—shooting out majestically and captured in its trajectory across space

and onto the flesh of an other—is proof of viability, identity, worth. With this, a man believes he has solved the secret of what women want and how to satisfy them;² he also has proved himself to be a “man”—the incitement to arousal here which, in its combination of money and sexual pleasure in the money shot, also “perfectly embodies the profound alienation of contemporary consumer society” (Williams 1989:107).

Starting even before *Go Renjā*, there has been a fetishization of metallic bodies and their crossover to and from humans in kids’ mass entertainment in Japan, from *anime* and live-action shows on television to *manga*, children’s magazines, toy merchandise, and movies. Like the caress of the pornographic camera that lingers, lovingly, over the body parts and activities of greatest exposure, the gaze in these *mecha* fictions fixates on the details of the metallic-human interface. Staging these sites/sights is not sexuality, in this case, but warfare. Fighting is the *raison d’être* for possessing cyberbodies, and displaying these bodies (in all their intimate detail) is occasioned by a battle: in preparation for, wounded from, or in the very heat of attack.

This is true, for example, of *Tetsujin 28gō* (Iron Man No. 28), a comic created by Yokoyama Mitsuteru in 1956 that later was made into a television show (exported to the United States under the name *Gigantor*). The main character is a giant metal monster operated by a remote-control device usually in the hands of Kintō Shotarō, a young boy “private detective” who, in partnership with the machine, thwarts many evil plots by nasty humans. The main power of this *mecha*, not autonomous like Atomu nor as technologically advanced, was brute force, yet great energy was put into constructing, staging, and displaying his machinery. Yokoyama has said that three things influenced his creation: “One was the sight I saw when the war ended and I returned to [my home] Kobe from my rural evacuation site. Everything as far as I could see had been transformed into scorched earth and piles of rubble. . . . I was . . . stunned by the destructive power of war. Second was the V1 and V2 missiles that the German Nazis developed. I had heard that Hitler tried to use these as an ace in the hole to reverse his waning fortunes. The third influence was from the American movie *Frankenstein*” (quoted in Schodt 1988b:78).

In the story, *Tetsujin 28gō* was designed by the Japanese military during the war to be their “ace in the hole,” but because all the previous models failed and the war came to an end, the machine became a civilian robot. *Tetsujin 28gō* triggered a fad in warrior robots, many of which were similarly fashioned as giants. A somewhat different style in *mecha* fetishism came from *Mazinger Z*, Nagai Gō’s comic that started in 1969 (and later was animated for TV) featuring a young hero, Kōji Kabuto, who is the pilot of a

hovercraft that docks in the head of a giant robot, serving as both its cockpit and its control center. Melding vehicle with robot and weaponry with cutting-edge technology, *Mazinger Z* also initiated a new style in robotic fashion: samurai chic (intermixed with an insect motif) of brightly colored surfaces, a knight’s visor, and both wing and horn protrusions on its helmet. Plots were standard: battles between *Mazinger Z* and various monsters, including robots. But it is his fusion of hero and machine that defines the genius and legacy of Nagai Gō in the *mecha* imaginary of postwar Japan, as Frederik Schodt notes: “The man-robot symbiosis that *Mazinger Z* symbolized helped solve an old problem in robot fiction—the problem of personifying the machine while still preserving its mechanical identity. When the robot became, like a car, a machine that could be jumped in and driven, it had a powerful appeal to young boys” (1988b:83).

One might recall here the movie *Gojira* and how Tsuburaya Eiji’s suit-mation special effect (having an actor play the monster dressed up in a rubber suit) was also regarded, particularly in Japan, where this technique was praised, as a “humanization” of, in this case, a monster. While this is a different order of “merging” than the robot-human symbiosis in *Mazinger Z*, it does involve a blending or crossing of bodily borders (human-machine-beast-vehicle) that mass storytelling in other countries (namely Hollywood) has been far less keen or quick to engage. How precisely bodies—of cyberwarriors as much as warrior robots—are constructed is obsessively deconstructed in what I call the “money shot” in an array of children’s entertainment in Japan’s postwar period. Movement is a central component here (from one state of being to another), as are power and performance upgrading to a higher level, that is, graphically and visually, marked by precise changes to the physical constitution. This is the logic of transformation (*henshin*), a central feature in the superhero myth and one excessively played up in *mecha* kids’ culture.³ Again, the trigger is always battle; alien attack triggers morphing, which itself is the trigger for the intricate and intimate display of mechanized bodies. While these stories foreground destruction, then, this theme is coupled with, and is the condition for, the staging of construction—how machines are built and humans transform into superheroic cyborgs.

In the plethora of books and magazines that publishers put out to accompany (and capitalize on) children’s shows, the superheroes’ special powers (*chikara*) are presented as “bodily secrets” (*karada no himitsu*) that are endlessly sketched, diagrammed, and displayed.⁴ For example, this is the case for a book, published by Shōgakukan in its “television picture book” series, on *Kamen Raidā Burakku* (Masked Rider Black), a live-action show that de-

buted in 1971 on TBS. Based on the *manga* series by Ishimori Shōtarō, it features a teenage boy who, killed in a motorcycle accident, is reconstructed as a cyborg. (As is typical of popular shows, *Kamen Raidā* ran for many seasons, and was even reprised in 2000, by continually morphing—changing costumes, weapons, vehicles, characters.) After being introduced as a “new hero” and *kaizō senshi* (artificial warrior) who transforms from a boy named Minami Kotarō into a cybergrasshopper, he is shown in his *henshin pōzu* (morphing poses): eight stances culled from martial arts. At stage eight, a power belt emerges seamlessly from inside the boy’s body, immediately encasing the hero in a *mecha* armature that fits his flesh as if it were a second skin. As his body fuses with this machinery, the boy morphs into a warrior whose *mecha* suit has both transformed and empowered him. The analogy with those superheroes of lean production, the Japanese corporate workers who don the same uniform at the start of every day, is noteworthy.

On the next foldout page is a huge picture of Kamen Raidā charting his “bodily secrets”: superpowerful arms used in the “rider chop,” the *henshin beruto* (morphing belt) that releases his energies, legs so strong he can jump ten times his height (called the “rider jump”), the squiggly mark on his chest that holds a mysterious secret, and eyes that can see even in pitch dark (figure 13). The descriptor “inside the body” refers here as much to the morphing belt as to legs, arms, and eyes, an indicator of how muddled the border between nature and cybernetics has become in the popular imaginary. On the following page, likewise, Kamen Raidā’s main riding machine, the *batoru hōpa* (battle hopper), is a “supermachine,” a *mecha* that can think, move, and live on its own. This talking motorcycle is simultaneously the warrior’s sidekick and his wheels; it also has the look of a naturalistic grasshopper (green, with insect legs off the back and, in the front, antennae and red laser eyes like its master’s). Here, too, all the supermachine’s powers are carefully charted. The book concludes by detailing Kamen Raidā’s fighting skills (the Raidā punch and kick), as well as outlining specifics about his enemies and his group of closest friends (*nakama*). In other accounts, weaponry (*buki*) figures as well: tools like the “beam gun” and “bio blade,” hybrids like everything else in this fantasy world. Graphing New Age powers (lasers, atomic rays) into old-style weaponry (swords, guns), cyber-*buki* also possess the ability to morph into totally different bodies (Kamen Raidā RX, for example, shifts into Robo Raidā and Bio Raidā).

The fascination with bodies and their reconstruction into fusions of insect/machine, human/tool, nature/technology proceeds along two axes in the genre of team warriors that began with *Go Renjā* in the 1970s. The first is transformation (*henshin*), and the second is union (*gattai*): assembling



Figure 13. The cyborgian “money shot”: revealing the “bodily secrets” of a mecha-hero. (From a *Kamen Raidā* illustrated book for children; courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd.)

the individual bodies, robots, and weapons of the Rangers into superconglomerates. A similar logic is at work in both: power parts that detach and come together according to a calculus that can be charted, studied, and copied with toy goods at home. In a book featuring the “superpowerful team warriors” (*Chōriki Sentai Ōrenjā*), the subtitle is “five-parted weaponry.” Shown first are the individual weapons of the Rangers: Red Ranger’s “star



Figure 14. Joining arms: five weapons combine into one—the principle of *gattai*. (From a *Choriki Ōrenjā* illustrated book for children; courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd.)

riser" (supersharpened knife), Green Ranger's "square crusher" (a pair of splicers), Blue Ranger's "delta tonfua" (a triangular knife), Yellow Ranger's "twin baton" (a pair of sticks), and Pink Ranger's "circular defender" (a high-powered shield). How all five pieces join together to form a megafirearm—the "*bīgu ban burasutā*" (big baton blaster)—is laid out next (figure 14). The delta tonfua goes on top, one baton on either side, the splicers in back, the shield behind, and the sword underneath. On the last two pages, the team of five is grouped together, jointly holding the super-machine (figures 15 and 16). According to Akira, an eight-year-old boy I talked to about *Ōrenjā*, the intricacies of *gattai* are as exciting as those of morphing ("*Sugoi yo, ryōhō*"—They're both great!). As he showed me with his piles of Ranger merchandise, this is a play universe bursting with body parts whose grammar of empowerment and assemblage is as flexible as it is complex. Akira could recite all the different constellations of this Ranger series, as well as those of the two previous seasons. Though he delighted in staging battles with his toys, the thrill of attaching, shifting, and rearranging *mecha*/body parts seemed every bit as great. And, in his play, transformation differed little from combination.



Figure 15. Fusing forces: the team with its conglomerate tool. (From a *Masukuman* illustrated book for children; courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd.)

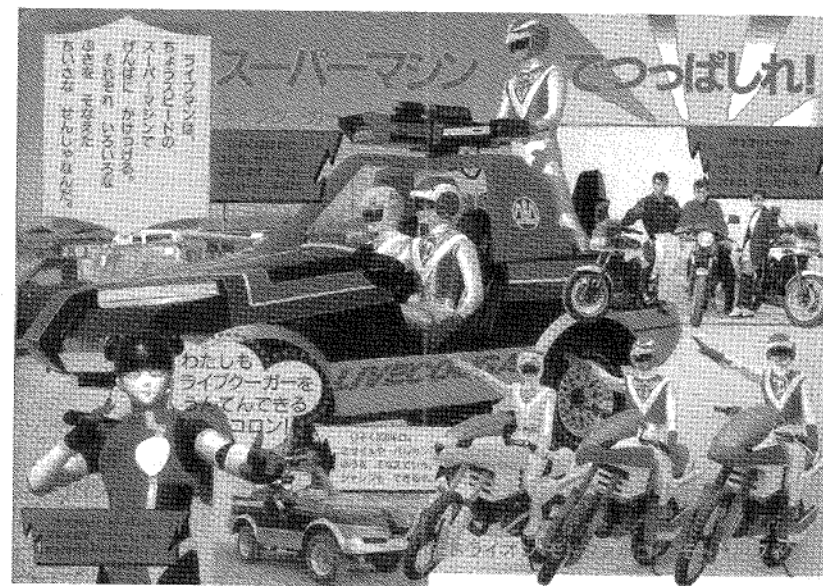


Figure 16. *Sūpa mashin* (supermachine): teaming machines and Rangers in the "live cougar" (From a *Chōsentai Raibuman* illustrated book for children; courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd.)

My own introduction to Japanese cybermorphers came in 1987–88, when I spent fifteen months in Japan with my family conducting research on Japanese motherhood and domesticity in Tokyo. My children were young, two and five, and my older son attended a Buddhist nursery school. Every Sunday morning my boys were parked in front of the television set watching the weekly slew of kids' shows that included two favorites, *Metaldar* (a red-suited morpher with a dog) and *Kamen Raidā Burakku*. The shows fascinated them, particularly my younger son, who developed a passion for superheroes and action figures that lasted more than ten years. At this age, he would race around the apartment in his Kamen Raidā helmet and power belt, slashing imaginary beasts with his trusty play sword. Over time, though, I noticed a far more subtle and sophisticated aesthetic sensibility at work. Adam would spend hours with action figures whose every stylistic detail he studied and knew: which weapons and musculature went with which figures, and how different versions were distinctly fashioned (by color, texture, costume, bulk, face, hair). While this particular sensitivity may not have come from the time he spent in Japan, a distinctive feature of Japanese toys is attentiveness to bodily detail.⁵ This is a signature of transformers, for example, which were a breakthrough hit of Japanese toys in the U.S. marketplace (though made-in-Japan tin jeeps and robots were popular after the war and through the 1950s, they always bore the cachet of cheap trinkets and were not nearly as trendsetting as the transformers). Launched jointly by Takara and by Hasbro-Bradley in the States in 1983 (and, in a similar though less popular toy line, as Gobots by Bandai and the American company Tonka in 1984), transformers were robots that morphed into vehicles. The idea of transformation, and its successful execution in a toy-body issuing multiple forms, parts, and changes, made transformers a kid craze (and produced more than \$100 million in sales for Hasbro in the first year alone).

The aesthetics of a profusion of small parts intricately arranged was something I observed frequently in the everyday environment of Japanese kids. For *oyatsu* (afternoon snacks, doled out daily at three), the stores sell a mesmerizing array of treats, packaged appealingly in tiny boxes that include not only a food substance (cookies, candies, crackers) but often a small toy. These *oyatsu* are like miniature Happy Meals, so affordable that kids can enjoy piles of them every day. Similarly, the monthly magazines popular with Japanese children come with a multisteped do-it-yourself toy: a big baton blaster, for example, with materials and instructions attached at the back. Assembly is complicated (as many as a hundred steps that must be studiously followed—a task that I, rather than my kids, routinely performed), but the end result is ingenious and cute. In the less commercialized realm of

nursery school, there were lunch boxes (*obentō*) to be made every day; these boxes, with movable borders or supplementary containers, are an effusion of bite-sized foods.⁶

Taken to the realm of kid toys, these aesthetics materialize in a parade of pieces with subtle differences, distinctions, and articulations. The *Ranger* series (and *mecha* shows like them) generate an endless quantity of stuff (figures, weapons, vehicles, robots), and each of these individual objects is further marked by its own set of (sometimes movable and detachable) parts. The kids I know who have been fans of such television fare, both in Japan and in the States (and going in between, as Adam did), almost invariably are fetishists of the consumer toys, craving as many goods as they can afford and also the latest editions. In Japan, the government imposes even fewer restrictions on commercial advertising for children than does the United States. Kids' consumer appetites are whetted by the fact that the *Rangers* TV show, for example, splices in ads for toy goods using the Ranger actors in action scenarios that are barely distinguishable from the program itself. (In the episode of *Ōrenjā* synopsisized at the beginning of this chapter, virtually all the commercials—before, during, and after the show—are for products branded by *Ōrenjā*. These include *Ōrenjā* candy, a children's magazine featuring *Ōrenjā*, an amusement park with a live *Ōrenjā* show, and two sets of toy merchandise by Bandai: the "transformer series" with weapons and the *Ōrenjā* robot. The Bandai ads are staged as action scenes using the very same actors in the television show using the very same equipment, making the transition from program to commercial virtually seamless.) Further, in media like monthly children's magazines, stories and comics are jump-cut with ads for commercial goods in a manner that effectively grafts the two together.

Consumerism, even that fashioned for young kids, hardly started with the broadcast of *Go Renjā* in 1973, but the 1970s marked the rapid development of a consumer culture in Japan that has increasingly targeted youth. Thus, alongside the principle of flexible production that shows up in the teamwork and cyberheroism of the Rangers, a new consumerism replete with an aesthetics of detail, newness, and high-tech design was fostered as well. These are the same characteristics—miniaturization, attention to detail, and stylish design—that, thanks to companies like Sony, Matsushita, and Nissan, established Japan's postwar reputation as a producer of high-quality consumer technology. On the home front, desire for such qualities in material goods was cultivated as well, of course. And in entertainments like *Go Renjā*, this desire was mapped at the level of the body: bodies whose secrets and powers translate into a host of commodifiable parts that are eagerly consumed by kids—almost as if they would like to bodily incorporate



Figure 17. Toy consumption/fantasy transformation: kids become superheroes in *Kamen Raidā* toy merchandise. (Courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd)

these goods themselves and, by doing so, thereby acquire the powers they promise (figure 17).

Instilling this appetite in children and (re)producing them as avid and future consumers was driven directly by toy companies like Bandai that, by taking over the sponsorship of children's television shows starting in the 1970s, crafted "money shots" on the screen that would translate, directly and repeatedly, to the desire to buy (their brand of) toy merchandise. Throughout the 1950s and '60s, manufacturers of candy or electric goods

were the main sponsors of kids' shows (Ezaki Guriko sponsored *Tetsujin 28gō*, for example), and, given the nature of their products, goods unrelated to the program itself (fans, radios, chocolates) filled the commercials. Toys derived from popular television (and *manga*) characters were being manufactured, of course, but toy companies (even those exporting to the United States) were mainly small and medium-sized ones that lacked the means to advertise much, if at all, on T.V. Further, only rarely did a single company have exclusive rights to a media character; in the case of *Tetsuwan Atomu*, for example, about twenty companies were involved in merchandising, which also led to a proliferation of toy incarnations.

All this changed in 1973 with Tōei Studio's *Go Renjā* when Bandai became the main sponsor and exclusive merchandiser. *Go Renjā* was Bandai's breakthrough hit, in fact, spiraling it into the ranks of one of the largest Japanese toy companies (and it is the largest today). Expanding the hero to a team of five, equipping them with an arsenal of multipart equipment, and reinventing the crew, along with its costumes and arms, each season were strategies intended to maximize the Ranger toy merchandise Bandai could market and also the desire, in kids, to acquire more and more of it (Hori 1996). This was also the start of the *gattai robotto* (joined robots) fad that, heating up in the middle to late 1970s, fueled many television shows (*Getta Robotto* in 1974, *Chōkiji Kon Batora-re* in 1976, and *Sūpa Sentai Shirizu* with its *kyōdai robotto*, giant robots, starting in 1979), accompanied by toys known for their complexity of detail (and high price).⁷ And, as Hori Takahiro has shown, there is a direct correlation between the degree and thematic of battle in a children's television show and sponsorship by a toy company. Using battle and transformation scenes as the trigger for toy merchandise—a proliferation of bodies, body parts, costumes, weapons, and vehicular *mecha*—toy companies promote this in programming and are less likely to sponsor those programs without battle scenes (Hori 1996:122–24).

But there is more to this morphing dreamworld. As a pop phenomenon that captured not only the United States but also the global channels of top-ranked television show and worldwide kids' fad for at least three years in the 1990s, its origin from a place other than the United States was historically unprecedented. Unlike what has defined the pathway for global kids' culture and entertainment in the postwar period before the 1990s—emanating from cultural industries centered in Euro-America and particularly the United States—*Power Rangers* comes from a new place (Japan) that decenters (and perhaps recenters) the production of global kids' culture. This, too, is an expression of a newly flexible world in which old mappings of identity and power are rearranged—or maybe not. For though the show originated

in Japan, it was radically transformed for broadcast in the States. Once again, as with *Gojira*, the Americanized version rather than the Japanese original became the global kids' hit *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers*. And neither Japan nor Tōei Studios, the producers of the television series that started in 1975 and is still running today, have been given much, if any, credit in the globalization of *Power Rangers*.

Rangers Do the States

It seems ironic that at a time when Congress has mandated more educational programming on television, children are going wild for a show filled with fight scenes and exploding monsters.

Bellafante 1993:88

During a visit to Japan in 1985, Haim Saban, then a newcomer to Hollywood seeking his fortune in entertainment, viewed an episode of *Jyū Renjā*, the 1985–86 season of *Rangers* with a dinosaur thematic. Struck by the dynamism of the show and the kinetic blend of morphing, live action, and cyberspirituality, Saban bought the rights from Tōei Studios the following year to air the show in the United States. What appealed to Saban as refreshing and new, however, was greeted by the networks he approached with flat-out rejection. Regarded as “silly,” “cheesy,” and “immature,” *Jyū Renjā* seemed too “foreign” to these executives, who predicted that American kids would not like its aesthetics. Compared with the Hollywood fare dominating the channels of children’s mass culture in the United States, *Jyū Renjā* was decidedly different. It was reminiscent, to some, of *Godzilla*: fantasy warfare staged to excess by special effects and monsters played by live actors. The tastes of American children were more sophisticated than this, it was thought, and so networks refused to sign *Jyū Renjā* on despite Saban’s persistence for eight years. It was only by finding an executive who was seeking something more “outrageous” than typical kid-show fare (Lippman 1997:A13) that Saban scored a deal. A fan herself of Japanese kids’ shows as a child, Margaret Loesch of Fox Kids’ network contracted *Jyū Renjā* to air in the States.⁸ She decided, however, to change the name and reshoot all the scenes of premorphed *Rangers* with American actors. In its reconstructed form, *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers* was launched by Saban and Loesch in August 1993. Within five weeks, the show became the top-rated children’s program on U.S. TV, generating unprecedented revenues for both Fox Network and Saban Entertainment (which subsequently merged, forming

Fox Kids Worldwide Inc. in 1996) and ballooning into a mega-fad with a show that is still airing a decade later.

Prior to the success of (what started at least as) *Jyū Renjā*, other Japanese media products had enjoyed a degree of exposure and fame in the postwar entertainment market of the United States. The televisual cartoon *Astro Boy* was popular enough in the 1960s to run for two seasons and generate a series of comic books. Waves of children’s shows followed, including *Speed Racer*, *Voltron*, *Robotech*, *Star Blazers*, and *The Starvengers*, though syndication was never nationwide, limited instead to certain geographic regions such as Hawai‘i and the West Coast. Transformer toys were big hits in the 1980s when, at the end of the decade, Japanese video games started selling as well. And *Godzilla*, of course, broke into the ranks of mainstream pop culture. Along with its offspring (*Ghidrah*, *The Three-Headed Monster*, *Rodan*, *Godzilla vs. Megalon*, etc.), *Godzilla* lasted until 1975, with a new wave in the 1980s and ‘90s, a final six-film burst starting in 1999 (Tsutsui 2004), and Hollywood’s crafting of its own version with TriStar’s *Godzilla* in 1998.

Overall, however, Japan figured little in the landscape of American mass culture prior to the 1990s. In part, this state of affairs reflects the hegemony of Euro-American and particularly U.S. cultural industries in both shaping global (pop) culture and dominating U.S. entertainment. Hollywood has been hostile to imports, and foreignness has largely been, and been seen as, an impediment to mass popularization in the United States. Yet Japan’s prestige as an economic superpower on the global stage has been in place since the late 1970s. Despite the strength of its economy and its status as the producer of quality consumer technologies (automobiles, electronics) that are popular and travel widely around the world, however, Japan’s cultural capital (in ideas, images, the imagination) has lagged behind. In the realm of global culture, that is, Japan has been a minor player. What has accounted for this gap between the economic and cultural currency held by Japan in the global marketplace in the last quarter of the twentieth century? And what significance is there to the fact that, for Americans, Japan’s biggest influence on the field of the imagination was embodied for decades in a radioactive lizard that signified, for many, the country’s subordinate status as a second-rate power?

It was precisely to dislodge this association between made-in-Japan and chintzy, cheap goods, in fact, that companies like Sony purposely designed and promoted their products in the export marketplace (primarily the United States and Europe when Sony started in the 1950s) as global (*sekai no*) rather than Japanese (*nihonteki*).⁹ Using muted colors (gray), a mod-

ernist style, and a global-sounding company name, Sony adopted what became a standard policy in postwar Japan of "denationalizing" (*mukokuseki*) its product—or, as the creator of the Walkman, Kuroki Yasuo, puts it, of making goods that "don't promote a particular Japanese look" (1995:12). Iwabuchi Kōichi calls this the "odorless" quality of Japanese exports (2002:33): deodorizing out the "smell" of Japaneseness was considered strategic both for those markets where their Japanese origin connoted inferior quality (Euro-America) and for those where it triggered memories of wartime brutalization (the Philippines, South Korea, and China, for example). Until recently, in fact, selling Japanese products worldwide has worked better in the domain of culturally neutral products: the "hard technology" of machines (televisions, VCRs, tape recorders) rather than the "soft technology" of what is transmitted on those machines (movies, television shows, music, idols).

This is true of the Walkman, Kuroki laments. As a vehicle of pop culture, the machine has had massive success and influence around the world, yet global users are rarely listening to Japanese music, a taste that remains primarily local (Kuroki 1995:13). One could also argue, however, that the Walkman blends, rather than conforms to, a rigid culture-versus-technology dichotomy. Many, including Kuroki himself, acknowledge the worldwide presence of a "Walkman culture," and in the way it reorganizes space/body/machine borders (thereby making reception a much more personal/mobile/customized operation), the Walkman could be called a "cultural technology" and Japan's global influence in this domain, tremendous.⁹ A crossing of borders is also at work in the *mecha* fantasies of the Ranger series, as we have amply seen. But bearing in mind the distinction Donna Haraway (1991) has made about cyborgs—they are tools used to make and enhance existence, and also myths by which we give imaginary shape to life in a technological age—we could also say that the traffic in Japanese tools (including cyborgian ones that remap the interface between human and machine) has flowed far more smoothly than that of its myths (including cybermyths) in the global marketplace. Indeed, as Iwabuchi (2002) and others have demonstrated, media products have, until recently, been particularly hard for Japan to market outside its own local borders.

Haim Saban had a singular goal in promoting the broadcast of *Jyū Renjā* on American TV. By reducing costs in producing children's programming, he hoped to build a global entertainment empire that would eventually outdistance Disney (Freeman 1993). The footage he had purchased from Tōei was cheap, and, indeed, production expenses were low for *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers*. By splicing together preshot segments with newly shot

scenes from the United States, Saban reputedly spent only \$150,000 per episode, compared with about three times that much for big studio productions.¹⁰ Once *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers* became a hit—only five weeks after first airing, it was the highest-ranked kids' show in Fox Network's history and quickly turned into a craze—Saban himself morphed into a major power broker in the field of kids' entertainment. His company, Saban Entertainment, which merged with Fox Kids Network in 1996 (forming Fox Kids Worldwide Inc., which later joined with Murdoch's News Corporation and was sold by Saban to the Walt Disney Co. in 2001), was producing 21 percent of all children's TV programming by 1997 (outranking Disney's 18 percent share and second only to Warner Brothers' 26 percent) and was predicted to make \$80 million in licensing fees alone for *Power Rangers*. Saban, the person who greatly facilitated the opening up of U.S. kids' entertainment to the presence of Japanese cultural goods, was motivated by strictly economic reasons. In an era when industrial countries' production was increasingly relocating overseas, Saban treated Japan—itsself an industrial power with a healthier economy than that of the United States in the 1980s—as an "outsourcer" in the field of kids' culture. In doing so, he viewed the world, including Japan, in terms not of bounded cultures but of "one big boundaryless marketplace": "We have this picture puzzle of various countries around the world, with each being able to generate a certain amount of money for certain products. And if we can make sense out of production by mixing Korean and Luxembourgish investments that would cover the production costs, then the rest of the world is open for sales" (Saban quoted in Heffley 1993:1).

Interests were different, it should be noted, for those brokering the sale of *Jyū Renjā* on the side of Tōei Studios. Watanabe Yoshinori, a director at Tōei for years, had long held the hope of "penetrating the U.S. market with Japanese popular heroes." Frustrated with Hollywood's xenophobia and its resistance to imports (the United States "thinks it's the best country" and will not "recognize foreign productions"), he wanted to familiarize American audiences with the strengths of Japanese creators by airing *Jyū Renjā* in the States. His dream was that "American kids would get wrapped up in a Japanese type of hero" and, with this base, "made-in-Japan heroes would get established around the world" (Ōshita 1995:297). Disappointingly, for Watanabe at least, the Rangers became more identified as American than Japanese heroes when *Jyū Renjā* morphed into *Power Rangers*. This was Saban's call, however, for in contracting with Tōei, he acquired exclusive rights to all licensing of the product outside Japan and scattered Asia Pacific markets. And Saban was motivated only by what would sell, first to Ameri-

can kids, and then to "global kids" in the international marketplace. For him, what made sense was keeping what he found different and fresh in the show, but delinking this from its Japanese origins and repackaging the Rangers as American. In his mind, this made *Power Rangers* a type of cultural hybrid: a "bridge," as he called it (Cody 1994:1), between the two countries. But its Japanese character, for the most part, fell out. The remade *Power Rangers*, with no references to the original in the credits and promotion, has become, in the words of a Saban executive I interviewed in 1997, "an American classic."

Hitting U.S. airwaves in August 1993, *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers* featured five seemingly normal American teenagers who morph into superheroes to fight alien enemies and restore peace to their California town. Targeted at three- to eleven-year-olds (somewhat older than its target of two- to seven-year-olds in Japan), the program deviated from the norm in children's entertainment by being live action instead of animated cartoon and showcasing a new brand of superheroism. The heroes worked as a team, used martial arts in their transformation, fought hordes of intergalactic foes, and were superheroically wired by an admixture of dinosaur spirits and high-tech machines. Most adults found the effect "cheesy" at best, yet kids were enraptured, catapulting *Power Rangers* to the highest-ranked kids' show almost immediately and cascading into a multidimensioned fad of mythic proportions soon afterward. Reproduced as videotapes, Fruit of the Loom underwear, McDonald's Happy Meal toys, a live show, and Kraft food products, the "Morphinomenon" was well on its way by Christmas, when shortages of the Bandai-produced toys led to huge scrambles at Toys "R" Us and IOUs brought by Santa for goods that would not arrive for weeks. Fiscal third-quarter sales of *Power Ranger* merchandise in the States totaled almost \$19 million, six times what had been originally expected. The news channels were filled with stories of fad frenzies, such as the record thirty-five thousand people who swarmed Universal Studios for an appearance of the Rangers, causing a traffic snarl for ten miles (Meyer, Tsiantar, and Schneideb 1994).

The reason for its explosive success, according to an executive at Bandai, was that *Power Rangers* was excitingly new and different and also that it fed into trends—dinosaurs, transformation, martial arts—that were already popular on the American kid scene in the early 1990s (Biederman 1994). The totemic motif of dinosaurs in *Jyū Renjā* (the sixteenth in the Ranger series in Japan) was inspired by the Hollywood movie *Jurassic Park*. In the States, *Jurassic Park* came out in 1993 and generated a dinosaur blitz spread by everything from a McDonald's Happy Meal campaign to Barney, the

cuddly purple *Tyrannosaurus* that has been a toddler craze for more than a decade now. Transformation, the keyword of *Power Rangers*, was a motif already gaining popularity in the mythic stories of American mass culture in the 1990s. On the Hollywood screen, there was a boom in recycled superheroes brought back from the comic books and action television shows of American yesteryear (*Superman* alone came out in a series of four movies between 1978 and 1987). Transformer toys were also a fad in the 1980s, helping to create a more generic interest in morphing that characterizes a number of later popular television shows (*Xena, the Warrior Princess* and *Buffy, the Vampire Slayer* are only two). Martial arts was a third trope whose popular currency *Power Rangers* both tapped into and capped further. By the 1990s, it was a sport that had already been mainstreamed in the lives and imaginations of American kids. Karate dojos are now commonplace in strip malls across middle America, where children call their teachers sensei and respond to commands dictated in Japanese. Kung fu has also become a staple on the Hollywood screen. It is the signature of Asian actors like Bruce Lee, Jackie Chan, and Jet Li, picked up by such American headliners as Keanu Reeves in the cyber sci-fi film *The Matrix* and even the gal trio in *Charlie's Angels* (a TV show in the 1970s, recently remade as blockbuster movies).

As can be seen, even before *Power Rangers* settled into the fabric of American kid culture, the latter was already textured by a mélange of elements, some influenced from abroad, including Japan. While such hybridity is certainly a sign of the times, marking the spread between geopolitical borders of various entities, including the fantasies and fictions of pop culture, there was hard-core resistance by American networks to importing this made-in-Japan *mecha* myth. This may have been motivated, in part, by what was a national rash of Japan bashing (as against Sony's buyout of Columbia Studios and Matsushita of Universal in 1989) brought on by an economic slump in the States just when Japan was experiencing the height of its Bubble economy. Overtly, however, rejection of the show was based largely on aesthetic grounds—that it diverged from Hollywood conventions of mythmaking (including standards against violence in kids' fare) and was too "hokey," "cheesy," and "low tech" (Heffley 1993:1). When *Power Rangers* was picked up by Fox Network, then, "localizing" the show to make it adhere more to American standards was considered imperative. The first change was replacing the Japanese actors with Americans for all the scenes shot with Rangers in flesh mode (out of their morphing costumes). Based on the assumption that American viewers would not identify with Asian faces, the new footage also moved the setting from Tokyo to California and de-

picted "normal American kids who shoot baskets, mall-hop and do aerobics—when they are not fighting space aliens." The result was a "campier, California version of the Power Rangers" (Cody 1994:1). The show merged those elements Saban wanted to keep from the original (good kids trained in martial arts who work hard together as a team) with additions for the American remake⁵ (a multiethnic, gender-blended team with the violence toned down and the moral message heightened). In his own mind, Saban made *Power Rangers* something of a politically correct enterprise in that the team had more girls (two rather than the one in *Jyū Renjā*), was ethnically diverse (a Latino, a black, an Asian American, and two whites in the first team), and fought alien invaders as a cooperative collective.⁶

For the toy marketers of *Power Rangers*, the show's success in the States signaled their entry into the global marketplace (figure 18). Bandai, now the largest Japanese toy company, has licensed the Ranger property since the show first aired in 1975 and, as Bandai America, won the license to the *Power Rangers* line when American toy companies were initially uninterested. Until its windfall with *Power Rangers*, Bandai's business built from reproducing movie and television characters into toys had never succeeded outside the domestic market. Its characters, such as Urutoraman (Ultra-man), with his metallic body and laser-beam eyes, were simply "too foreign" for Americans, according to Yamashina Makoto, Bandai's president (Cody 1994:1). An executive at Bandai America agrees, saying that Japanese characters needed to be adjusted to the tastes and "psyche" of American kids before they could be sold in the United States (Peter Dang quoted in Cody 1994: 1). This meant giving American faces and bodies to the unmasked Rangers and giving more emphasis to the female characters as well as the everyday lives of the Rangers as "normal teens." In Bandai's company directive for 1997, such localization strategies are referred to as "globalization" ("creating major attractions which transcend national boundaries"; Bandai Kabushikigaisha 1997:6). This is one of the two pillars of corporate vision (the other is "diversification," meaning commodifying characters beyond mere toys, including "items such as clothing, food products, and other everyday goods"; 5). If, in the process of globalization (localizing global products—for example, McDonald's adding beer to its menu in France and spicy chicken in China), character merchandise that started off as Japanese is (re)identified as something else, this does not upset the company at all, I was told by executives in Tokyo during an interview in 1996. Why should we care if we are making profits around the world? Blending different cultural codes is part and parcel of a global marketing strategy, according to these Bandai officials. And even if the brand goes from being Japanese to Ameri-

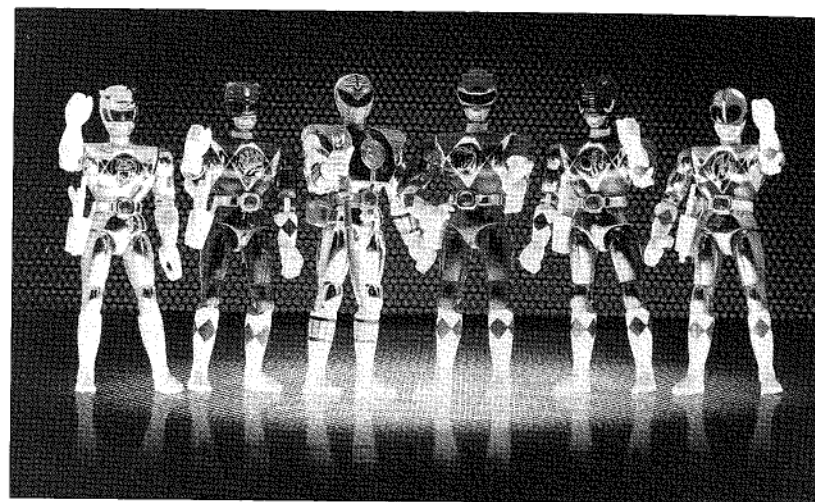


Figure 18. Ranger toys for the United States by Bandai America. (Courtesy of Bandai America Incorporated)

can, this alteration reflects the flexibility of product marketing in a world marked by global capitalism.

Bandai is on the same page as Saban in its marketing policies. And kids, both in the United States and around the world, have delighted in a show that mixes morphing, monsters, and martial arts and juxtaposes stylized action scenes (shot in Japan) with the everyday dramas of Californian teens (shot in Hollywood). "I think it's cool the way kids transform and fight. And I like the monsters; they're weird but interesting, like the recent kangaroo whatchamacallit beast" (an eight-year-old American girl speaking of the 2003 season *Power Rangers Ninja Storm*). Indeed, by 1995, *Power Rangers* was airing in more than fifty countries (today it is fifty-three) and remained the top-ranked children's television show around the world for three years and, in the United States, through 1995 (in two categories, boys ages two to eleven and overall kids ages two to eleven). When its popularity began fading in 1996 and Saban called a meeting with his top five licensees to decide whether to discontinue it, he decided to invest even more resources into getting "people to believe in it again" because toy sales were still so strong.¹¹ Thus, as in Japan, the Rangers have been driven both by and for toy marketing. And the investment has paid off; *Power Rangers* toys were declared the top-ranking "male action toy brand" for both the year 2000 and the decade of the 1990s by the NPD Group Inc (the toy industry's sales-tracking

organization), and the television show was proclaimed the "most popular kids' show of the 1990s" by Nielsen Galaxy Explorer. In the process, Saban, who refers to himself as a "cartoon schlepper," has purchased Fox Family, become chairman and CEO of Fox Family Worldwide Inc., and is considered one of the wealthiest and most powerful brokers of kids' entertainment in Hollywood (and the world) today. Bandai (and Bandai America) also has supersized its operation and reputation in a way that would have never been possible without this crossover breakthrough into the mainstream of American pop culture/kids' marketplace.

Mighty Morphin Toyota: Lean Production Conquers America

Don't expect to get it. *Power Rangers* is choppy, video-game-paced fare that has the feel of a cheap Japanese monster movie circa 1956. The premise: five teenagers (three boys and two girls) are transmogrified mid-episode into spandex-clad superheroes who battle the evil forces of Rita Repulsa, an intergalactic witch. Through a mix of kung-fu acrobatics, pummeling and pouncing, the Rangers manage to defeat whatever band of clunky, plastic robot-cretins Rita enjoins to cause trouble.

Bellafante 1993:88

Interestingly, what has drawn American kids to *Power Rangers*—the frenetic pace, stitching together of disparate elements, and morphing oscillations between teenage everydayness and fantasy cyberwarriorship—is precisely what adults (particularly when the show first started in the mid-1990s) have found to be bewildering and problematic.¹² A review in *Parents' Magazine*, for example, called its popularity "inexplicable," saying that *Power Rangers* "grafts stories about teen-age do-gooders onto campy Japanese kung-fu fighting footage" (McCormick 1995:231). According to another review, "*Power Rangers* is choppy, video-game-paced fare that has the feel of a cheap Japanese monster movie circa 1956" (Bellafante 1993:88). In *Newsweek's* account, "Adults are hard pressed to explain the Rangers' appeal. Certainly the plotline is cheesy at best." Similarly, for a special (in December 1994) on the ABC show *20/20*, John Stossel reported: "Why it's so popular isn't clear. From an adult perspective, it's an astonishingly stupid show. Five teens from the suburbs transform themselves—'morph' they call it—into superheroes in Spandex so they can fight Godzilla-like monsters. . . . This is cheap production . . . all the fight scenes are done in Japan. American teens are added later for the American audiences" (December 16, 1994).

The mixing of cultural codes on the show grated on the nerves and sensibilities of American adults. Yet by 1993—the year of *Power Rangers'* debut in the States—Japanese influence in other spheres of American life, most notably industrial production and high-tech consumer goods, was already well established. This was particularly true of what has been widely identified as Japan's model of (lean/flexible) production that had become increasingly assimilated into the workplace and consumer tastes of millions of Americans. In car trends, leaner Japanese makes were replacing gas-guzzling American behemoths following the oil shock of 1973. And on the factory floor, Toyotism—just-in-time, small-batch production—was overtaking Fordism in the wake of debilitating developments in the U.S. economy, and American industry, starting in the 1960s. The American car industry had been particularly hard hit by massive shutdowns, layoffs, and a declining market (both domestically and internationally) for American-made cars. Imports from Europe and Japan rose rapidly in the 1970s (desirable for their lower cost, higher fuel efficiency, and quality), triggering radical shifts in car design as well as automobile production in the home of Ford(ism).

Innovation came, most notably, from Japan. Japanese methods of flexible, lean production were widely adopted in the U.S. car industry along with what some call a Japanese management style, or "Toyota culture." In some cases, Japanese companies like Nissan and Toyota physically took over failed car plants, becoming, as a number of studies labeled them, "Japanese transplants" on American soil, as in Terry Besser's sociological study entitled *Team Toyota: Transplanting the Toyota Culture to the Camry Plant in Kentucky* (1996). The interbreeding of two distinct production styles and work cultures in car plants across middle America (Ohio, Kentucky, California) was heavily reported in the mass media. It also filtered into pop culture; in the Hollywood movie *Gung Ho* (1988), for example, the story of the Japanese buyout of a shut-down car plant in Pennsylvania was played comedically as the clash of two cultures by Michael Keaton and Watanabe Ken. Driven by the tension of cultural difference, the plotline, in this case, proceeds to a successful resolution; the different strands of work culture are sutured together to produce a functional hybrid—a U.S.-Japanese car plant.

Needless to say, *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers* is a hybrid as well. It literally stitches together two productions—one by Tōei in Japan and the other by Fox Network in the States—each engineered by different production crews, standards, and conventions. From this fact alone, we can see the signs of a postmodern aesthetics: one that, contrasted with the relative stability of Fordist modernity, celebrates difference, ephemerality, spectacle,

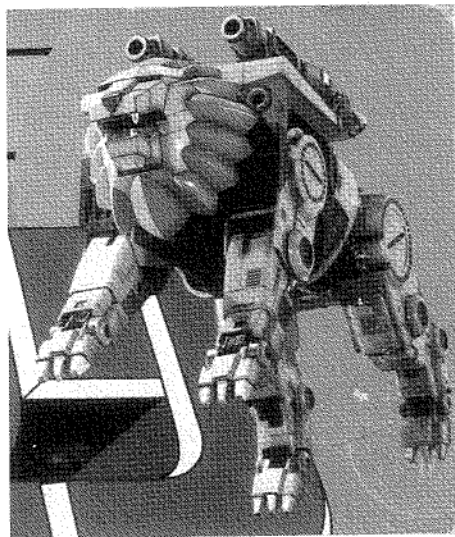


Figure 19. "Future-primitive" aesthetic: a vehicular robot as lion. (From a *Chōsentai Raibuman* illustrated book for children; courtesy of Tōei Company Ltd.)

fashion, and the commodification of cultural forms (Harvey 1989). As Fredric Jameson (1984) characterizes the cultural logic of late capitalism, postmodernism revels in a heterogeneity of styles that crossbreeds historicities, cultures, and artifacts in a pastiche aesthetic. Such a coding is evident in *Power Rangers*, with its jump-cutting between stylized action scenes shot in Japan and American teenage dramas filmed in Hollywood. But this aesthetic of fusing styles from different cultures, histories, or genres is also apparent in the Japanese original of the Ranger series. In *Jyū Renjā*, "normal" teenagers move between futuristic transformation and traditional martial arts, and their bodies bleed with prehistoric dinosaur spirits as well as New Age cybermachines.¹³ Writing in the *Village Voice*, Erik Davis calls this "future-primitive" (figure 19), an aesthetic strikingly different from that upheld in Hollywood. "Unlike America's reigning ideology, which holds that 'good' effects—like *Terminator 2*'s morphing—are simulacra dependent on the latest technological developments, the Power Rangers present an old-fashioned tacky futurism that is sufficient unto itself" (1994:74). Davis

traces the "future-primitive" to *Godzilla*, in which technology figures more prominently in the story itself—transforming a prehistoric beast into a beastly nuclear weapon—than in the high-tech film/television production upheld by Hollywood.

Like other reviewers, Davis is unsettled by what he treats as an alien aesthetic masquerading as American pop culture in *Power Rangers*. Most disturbing of all is the fear that these time-shifting Rangers may in turn transform the identities and consumer tastes of American kids: "But when they morph, the American team doesn't just don costumes, they mutate their core identities. The rough transition and lack of continuity between the Japanese and American footage is a sign of . . . the dreamlike and monstrous scrambling of cultural codes. Our Wonder Bread heroes are not just turning Japanese, they're becoming altered beings in a parallel aesthetic realm, with its own internal logic, myths, and ethics. And maybe their audience is somehow transforming too. . . . The tykes currently addicted to the show may end up becoming a mass market for more mature and vital Japanese popular shows now shrouded in hipster subculture—e.g., anime" (Davis 1994:73).

Besides violating the cultural codes of American aesthetics, there has also been the charge that *Power Rangers* is an excessively violent show that leads to heightened aggression in American kids. In fact, when the show was first becoming a global fad in 1993, a number of countries (Norway, Denmark, Canada, New Zealand) banned it after an incident in Norway in which a five-year-old girl was kicked to death by playmates supposedly mimicking a Ranger warrior stance. According to one U.S. study, *Power Rangers* accrues more acts of violence per show (two hundred per hour) than any children's programming to date in American broadcasting. The two educators who conducted the study, Diane Levin and Nancy Carlsson-Paige, also interviewed primary and nursery school teachers, 97 percent of whom voiced "at least one" concern about the effect *Power Rangers* was having on children in the classroom. As they concluded, what is disturbing about the show is not only its central trope of fighting to resolve problems but also the added, and sanctioned, "realism" this warfare has when the medium is live action, where, it is assumed, kids have a harder time distinguishing fantasy from reality than they would in a cartoon (Levin and Carlsson-Paige 1995:67, 69). As they and others, such as Sissela Bok (1998), have argued, shows like *Mighty Morphin Power Rangers* are promoting increased aggression and a desensitization to violence in American kids these days. Opposing this view, however, is another: that the show and the stylized rituals of play it promotes are also experienced as empowering to kids—a vehicle

for confronting, and overcoming, challenges, struggles, and obstacles (whether they be personal or mythical, as the two are often coupled in the shows themselves).

The issue of media violence and its effect on children, in both their real lives and their imaginations, is a complicated one, particularly when dealing with cross-cultural sites.¹⁴ (In Japan, for example, there is less public anxiety about media violence, and it is far more tolerated in venues targeted to kids, yet actual violence—as calculated by criminal acts of homicide, bodily injury, armed robbery, and theft—is vastly less common than in the States, where outcries against violent media have been far more pronounced.) This is an issue I return to in the discussion of *Pokémon*, a playscape that, despite its foregrounding of continual matches among the “pocket monsters”—in which the latter are stunned, blasted, poisoned, whiplashed, and smacked—has generated almost no concern about violence in the United States. To end the current discussion, though, I merely return to my earlier point about the conjoining of battle and body configuration in the *Rangers*.¹⁵ Fetishized here is the dissection of *mecha*/cyberheroes, whether the focus is on the makeup (as in the various weapons/accessories/spirits that constitute the makeup of characters) or breakdown (as in the way these characters repeatedly come undone when attacked) of the subject’s parts—a distinction that itself becomes indistinguishable. Hence, an interest in the composition of cyborg bodies and their multiple parts (robots, armor, weapons, computers) bleeds into an interest in the decomposition (smashing, chopping, evisceration, death) that bodies undergo as a consequence of violent fighting. Thus, though coming at it from opposite ends, as it were, both the constructive and the destructive components of *mecha* superheroes are part and parcel of the same geometry: power as it fuses and defuses in bodies with shifting and exploding borders of identity.

This elaborate, interchangeable, and mobile multipartedness is what I see as the appeal of the fantasy; it is what has made the *Rangers* series such a long-lasting fixture in the terrain of postwar Japanese kids’ culture and, more recently, such a global craze in the worldwide marketplace of cyber-infected, techno-mobilized, post-Fordist kids. Though *Power Rangers* can be read as a postmodern allegory, it is also a commercial property, and one designed to entertain and sell (to) children. From this perspective, what is de-centered and diffuse in the *Rangers* also sells multiple goods: teams of heroes each with their own sets of powers and tools, all of which are seasonally replaced. As a Japanese mother bemoaned, every Christmas she buys her son the biggest and latest Ranger superrobot, which is invariably outdated by March, the start of the new season. Hideki was playing next to us, mak-

ing battle and flying sounds with the *Ōrenjā chōriki gattai robo* (the super-power collateral robot on the *Ōrenjā* series). Immersed in his fantasy play, the child kept retrieving other equipment from a huge box: a dagger sword, a “king blaster,” a Yellow Ranger.

Just as rich as the imaginative world Hideki entered was the abundance of material goods he acquired. A vice president at Bandai America articulated this principle as the cardinal axiom of his business: “The show is the fantasy, and the toy is the material realization of that fantasy for the child to play with on his own.”¹⁵ With *Rangers*, the fantasy is so constructed that it is materialized in a wealth of commodifiable bodies, tools, and “spirits” with a shelf life that is breathlessly short. The principles involved, then, are those of fetishistic consumption as well as flexible production, fulfilling Marx’s insight about the constant (re)creation of capitalist desire whose satisfaction is forever deferred. In Benjamin’s words, *Power Rangers* is an enchanted “fairy scene” in which commodities are sold as fantasies and myths. And transformation is the key to this postindustrialized dream: a mythic trope that serves the interests of capital and shapes the fantasies of kids at this moment of the twenty-first century.